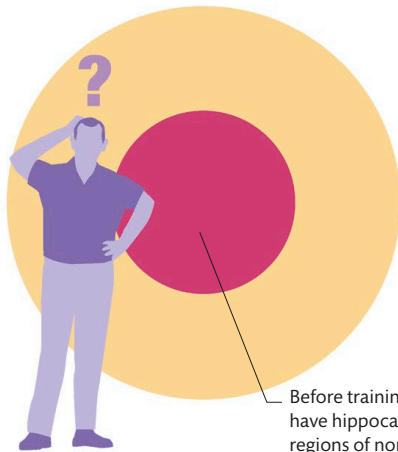




KEY

● Taxi driver's hippocampus

● Taxi driver's posterior hippocampus



Before training, taxi drivers have hippocampi with regions of normal size

1 Same size

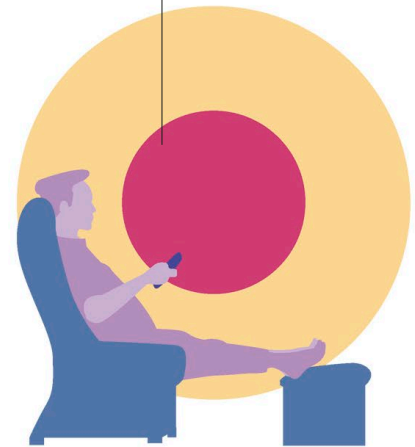
At the start of the study, scientists scanned the brains of the participants to measure the size of their hippocampi. There were no differences between the trainee taxi drivers and the control group.



Posterior hippocampus increases in volume

2 Changing anatomy

The trainee taxi drivers who passed "the Knowledge" had larger posterior hippocampi than the control group, or the trainees who failed. Some studies found that the front of their hippocampi was smaller.



Posterior hippocampus returns to original size

3 Returning to normal

The brains of retired taxi drivers look much more like those of the control group. This suggests that the changes to the hippocampus revert once taxi drivers stop using "the Knowledge" on a daily basis.

"Photographic" memory

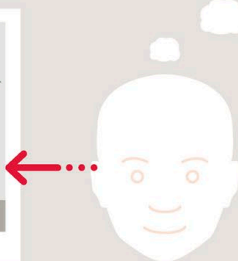
There is no such thing as photographic memory—no one can literally recall pages of text or images as if they were really in front of them. The closest is eidetic memory, which occurs in 2–10 percent of children. After looking at an image, "eidetikers" continue to "see" it in their visual field, until it gradually fades or disappears as they blink.

Picture imperfect

Studies have shown that eidetic images are not perfect. Children may not manage to remember all the letters in a word they were shown, or they may invent details, for example, "recalling" something in a picture that was not really there.



PHOTOGRAPH



CHILD



MEMORY

Sometimes, people with an eidetic memory vividly recall details that were not present in the original scene, such as the color of this roof

CAN PEOPLE REMEMBER EVERYTHING?

A perfect memory does not exist, but a few people have superior autobiographical memory, giving them exceptional recall for events during their lives.

PEOPLE WITH INCREDIBLE RECALL FOR FACES ARE CALLED SUPER RECOGNIZERS

